

The first 10 AI customers are not bought.

- They are recruited.

WHY NORMAL SAAS ADVICE BREAKS

Most GTM playbooks assume the wrong world.

- The product is deterministic.
- The buyer knows the workflow.
- The demo represents reality.
- Early AI startups usually have none of these.

MOVE 1

Pick a workflow you can run live in a meeting.

- "We help analysts" is not a wedge.
- "We turn this exact input into the output your team signs off on" is a wedge.
- Specificity closes.

MOVE 2

Trade integration work for design-partner rights.

- Build the integration.
- Get weekly feedback.
- Negotiate the right to generalize what you learn.
- Without that last part, it becomes custom consulting.

MOVE 3

Charge real money on day one.

- Free pilots create polite feedback.
- Small paid pilots create honest feedback.
- The amount matters less than the fact that the customer made a real decision.

MOVE 4

One founder owns the whole loop.

- Cold note.
- Demo.
- Integration.
- Onboarding.
- 30-day check-in.
- Do not outsource the learning too early.

THE UNCOMFORTABLE TRUTH

Your first customers pay for founder attention.

- That is fine.
- The startup question is whether that attention becomes repeatable product learning.

READY FOR CUSTOMER 11?

Scale only when these four things are true.

- You can predict who will sign.
- The integration takes days, not weeks.
- The customer's success metric is legible.
- You know who you should not sell to.

FULL ESSAY

The first 10 customers are the product.

- I wrote the full playbook on my site.
- Link in the post comments.